Sharpies

By David Narter

(BRETT and CHRISTINA are in a waiting room in which there is a single chair upon which is a scattering of brochures and forms. CHRISTINA is pacing. Frequently, they look toward the audience - the window of the playroom.)

CHRISTINA: Oh, God. This is so nerve-wracking.

BRETT: No. Tyler's fine. He'll do fine. *(Long pause)*

CHRISTINA: Did you talk with him last night?

BRETT: Excuse me?

CHRISTINA: When you two were out for ice cream, you were supposed to talk to him about this.

BRETT: About what? What am I supposed to tell him? Be smart?

CHRISTINA: So you didn't talk to him? Brett, you were supposed to let him know the situation and what was expected of him.

BRETT: Oh, Christina. C'mon. Does it really matter what I say to him? He's going to be doing arts and crafts and listening to story time.

CHRISTINA: Yes, it matters! Some of these kids are going to cry as soon as they get here and some kids are going to be comfortable in the situation and doing what they're supposed to do - maybe going beyond what's expected, Brett. Are you familiar with that expression, Brett? Beyond what's expected?

BRETT: Christina, I'll be happy if he doesn't eat the paste.

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INTRODUCTION

It's that time of the year! Application forms, tests, early admission, teacher recommendations, and even a sleepless night or two. Time to apply for college? Try preschool! Twenty years ago, they just had to show up and not eat glue. These days it seems that if a kid isn't 'gifted', they're behind. In fact, in many of the larger cities (New York, San Francisco, Chicago) spots are limited and it can be super competitive.

What exactly are elite pre-schools looking for? According to Patty Washburn of the North Shore Country Day School, "We are not looking for children who can just handle the program; we also want children who can give something back to the class." So often, applicants (ie children) are observed in a "play-date" setting with numerous others to see how they fit in.

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BRETT: Seriously, how does watching him play tell them anything about him.

CHRISTINA: It doesn't, Brett. It tells them about us.

BRETT: What?

CHRISTINA: How we parent. That's what they want to know.

BRETT: So this is about us. Don't you think that's a little self- centered?

CHRISTINA: Ugh! So did you tell Tyler anything at all, Brett?

BRETT: Well actually, I told him ... *(in an announcer voice)* "kill the competition!"

CHRISTINA: What are you talking about?

BRETT: It's an ad. It was an ad for Home Depot or something. He was a little freaked out, and I told him it was a figure of speech about competition and doing your best. I told him ... confidence. *(reconsiders and then comes back to it)* Confidence.

CHRISTINA: Oh. Oh. Well, good.

BRETT: Yeah. You know, I wasn't really talking about this at all though. It was actually - to be honest, I think he was kind of freaked out about the slogan. So, I just kind of generalized.

CHRISTINA: Well, sure. You tell a toddler to "kill the ... "

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BRETT: Right. Listen, Christina, I said that there's lots of people and you have to do your best if you want to get noticed. That's all.

CHRISTINA: Right. Well good. That's good. That's good. So why didn't you just tell me that when I asked?

BRETT: Because I wasn't really talking about this. I mean I think he really thought about it, but I don't remember if I really said anything specific about today.

CHRISTINA: Hmm. Well, that's fine. I did.

BRETT: Yeah? When?

CHRISTINA: When we were driving in.

BRETT: What'd you say?

CHRISTINA: Same as you.

BRETT: Yeah?

CHRISTINA: Yeah, I told him that there are a lot of other kids who he'll see in his life and a lot in the room today and there are winners and there are losers. I told him it's best to think of himself as the sun and always make sure the teacher can see him shining bright. And that it is his job to be sure no one got in the way of his sunshine. *(Long pause)*

BRETT: Oh.

CHRISTINA: I just reminded him that it's a big world. And one little person can get crowded out by a lot of the mediocrity around him if he doesn't make sure he gets himself in the front of the line. Just like you - kill the competition.

BRETT: Just like me? I told him to be confident! I didn't tell him to "kill the competition"!

CHRISTINA: Well, neither did I.

BRETT: Are you kidding????

CHRISTINA: *(realizing this is getting out of hand)* Brett. Brett. Listen. Listen. You said it

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before. This isn't about Tyler. It's about us.

BRETT: I didn't say that. You did.

CHRISTINA: Anyway. We don't want to be arguing when they're watching **him**. Tyler is going to be Tyler and he's a part of us both. And I'm sure they'll see the best of us when they see him. Okay? Okay?

BRETT: Yeah, you're - right. *(looks to audience: a glass through which they can see Tyler play)* Hey, there he is!

CHRISTINA: Hey, baby. Who's my little handsome man? *(MR. GLENN enters)*

MR. GLENN: Oh, he can't see you. That's a one-way window -- or mirror. I suppose it all depends on which side you're on.

BRETT: Well, that's a little creepy.

MR. GLENN: Oh, for the most part it's pretty benign. We use it to evaluate staff members usually. But of course, assuming Tyler is accepted into the program, you're always welcome to watch him play without affecting the ... the chemistry of the classroom environment.

CHRISTINA: Oh. That's nice. What a little fella. He's gonna do a little painting.

MR. GLENN: He's an interesting young man.

CHRISTINA: Really?!

MR. GLENN: Absolutely. We had a good conversation before we went in. He told me he got ice cream last night.

BRETT: Yes he did.

MR. GLENN: He also said something about the radio scaring him. It seems he was a little anxious about it.

CHRISTINA: Really?

BRETT: Yeah. There was some ad - really freaked him out. I changed the station.

CHRISTINA: Yeah. Tyler's a very quiet - well - thoughtful boy. He thinks a lot. *(long pause)*

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MR. GLENN: Well, that's good.

BRETT: Oh, look at that. He's got himself a girlfriend.

CHRISTINA: No, no. Tyler's teaching her how to paint.

BRETT: Yeah, how 'bout that? They're painting together.

CHRISTINA: No. He's teaching her.

MR. GLENN: Really?

CHRISTINA: He's teaching her how to paint. See he's helping her hold the brush. No. No. Take turns, now. Hmm.

BRETT: Whoa, yeah that's not a lesson. That's a fight.

CHRISTINA: Nonsense, he's helping her, but she's not paying attention.

BRETT: Hmm. Nope they're fighting over that brush. Yeah, that's a fight.

CHRISTINA: Well, of course it's not a fight. Tyler is twice her size. He's helping her.

BRETT: I don't know. Okay, that's a shove.

CHRISTINA: Hey, now! That really was a shove. That little girl just pushed Tyler down. Mr. Glenn, shouldn't the teacher be interceding at some point?

MR. GLENN: I'm not sure that she's seen it yet. Oh! *(All of them gasp in horror)*

BRETT: Oh, my God. That's just right in her eye!

CHRISTINA: No, of course it isn't.

BRETT: Oh, it's in there.

MR. GLENN: Oh dear. *(calling to be heard through the window)* Mrs. Schiff!

CHRISTINA: That's not his fault.

BRETT: Christina.

CHRISTINA: It's not his fault. That girl was pulling and he just let go. He was letting her have the brush. He was being generous!

MR. GLENN: Finally, she's noticed.

BRETT: Whoa that was quick!

MR. GLENN: We do have a nurse on sight. And if that button is pushed ... well, as you

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can see, she's there in an instant.

BRETT: Jeez, I am so sorry ... I don't know what happened there.

CHRISTINA: It was an accident.

MR. GLENN: Of course. Of course it was.

CHRISTINA: Tyler no, no. No, honey. There are other brushes, you don't need that one. Not that one! *(Horrified gasp from all three)*

BRETT: Oh. That just popped right out.

CHRISTINA: What? Why is she yelling at Tyler? Oh, c'mon now. She's just upsetting him more.

BRETT: *(rushing to the door of the observation room)* Okay, this is over. I'm going ... *(the door is locked)* Mr. Glenn. Do you have a key?

MR. GLENN: No. I didn't even know there was a lock.

BRETT: Well, there's something keeping this from opening!

MR. GLENN: Dear God. He's locked us in here.

CHRISTINA: That's ridiculous. Tyler could not have done that.

BRETT: There's no way out!!!

CHRISTINA: Tyler, honey. This is mommy. It's okay. It's okay.

MR. GLENN: He's going for the scissors!

BRETT: No, Tyler!

CHRISTINA: Tyler! Tyler! Use the roundies, honey. Not the sharpies, not the sharpies! *(Both men freeze and look at Christina in shock. Then, looking back at the window, they all gasp in terror)*

BRETT: There goes the nurse.

MR. GLENN: *(patting his pockets)* He's taken my cellphone!

BRETT: Christina. Your phone.

CHRISTINA: Don't be rude, Brett. *(Brett makes a dash for her purse and rifles through it till he gets the phone)*

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CHRISTINA: No. No. Tyler. That's not nice. Gentle hands. Gentle hands.

BRETT: *(fumbling with the phone)* C'mon! C'mon!

CHRISTINA: Don't you run with those scissors.

MR. GLENN: Why is he climbing up there? *(Their eyes follow him up a jungle gym)*

CHRISTINA: He's playing king of the mountain! He's a little Moufasa! *(She does a tiny wave)* Look, Brett. They're all his little subjects! *(Their eyes follow him jumping from the jungle gym. Again, the men gasp in horror and Brett drops the phone.)*

BRETT: Oh, God.

CHRISTINA: Tyler. Mouths are for food. No biting! No!

MR. GLENN: Oh, that's the entire ear!

CHRISTINA: Tyler, no! People are not food! No! *(Suddenly they all exhale.)*

MR. GLENN: Oh, dear God.

CHRISTINA: Oh, look who's tired. No. No. Find your own space. Let her sleep. No! *(As the men become even more shocked)* Hands to yourself, Tyler. Hands to yourself!

MR. GLENN: How ***did*** he ... ? He knew exactly where the heart was.

BRETT: Well, that's something.

CHRISTINA: We have a few anatomy CD's. He's very advanced.

MR. GLENN: Dear God, he's walking to window.

BRETT: It's like he can see us.

MR. GLENN: He's looking right at us!

CHRISTINA: Hi, baby. *(In baby talk)* Who's got the messy red hands? Who's my messy boy? No. No. Wipe on a towel sweety. Not the window.

MR. GLENN: *(recoiling in terror)* He sees us! He sees us!

CHRISTINA: Don't be silly. He's writing letters. C - O -

MR. GLENN: They're backwards. Oh God! He can see us!

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CHRISTINA: I know. He is very smart. Aren't you Tyler sweetie! Aren't you!

BRETT: N - F - I - D -

MR. GLENN: Confidence. He spelled confidence.

CHRISTINA: Oh, my little Moufasa is tired. Look at the little angel. He's just gonna lie down and have a "widdle nappie." *(She watches him lovingly while Mr. Glenn cowers in the corner, panting)*

BRETT: Mr. Glenn. I'm so ... well, I just don't know what to say.

MR. GLENN: There's nothing to say.

BRETT: Of course. Of course ... I just ... this is just... unbelievable.

MR. GLENN: Yes. Yes. *(He collects himself and organizes his notes. He then pulls two sheets from the stack.)* Well. You'll need to fill out these two forms. And I'll need a copy of Tyler's physical and a copy of your insurance card.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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